

“US Debt, International Spending Cuts, and the Sustainability of International Order”¹

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Abstract

This essay argues that if US preferences for austerity are real, international spending is a ready target, and international cooperation can survive US retrenchment. The Trump II administration is activating good-faith concern over the US debt burden to make cuts to the institutions and policy complements of the International Liberal Order (ILO). While shocking in depth especially absent an acute crisis, contractions are consistent with a precautionary approach to debt accumulation. Compared to alternatives, international spending – domestically misunderstood, with contested rates of return on investment – is a politically attractive outlet for first-order, non-cosmetic cuts. Further, history suggests both that the world can understand the links between US debt, domestic politics and international contraction, and that cooperation can endure regardless. Specifically, although in 1971 Nixon shocked the world by ending the Bretton Woods system of global exchange rate cooperation, economic integration adapted – and thrived – rather than collapsed.

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Introduction

Compromise over borrowing and spending is easier when money is cheap. Debates can leave the absolute numbers to the side and focus on the rate at which debt is growing (the second derivative), rather than the debt's growth itself (the first derivative). In contrast, when money is expensive, belts must be tightened. Households know this, businesses know this, and sovereigns know this too.

In its first months, the Trump II administration, with Elon Musk at the helm of the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE), pointed to the US debt to justify extreme austerity policies. Elon Musk aped the campaign gimmick pioneered by Argentina's Javier Milei – wielding a chainsaw in front of the cameras. In the administration's first televised cabinet meeting in February 2025, Trump nodded while Musk declared that with continued spending “the country will become de facto bankrupt.”²

Of course, the sovereign is neither a household nor a firm. Sovereigns have spending imperatives far afield from family or profit-maximizing business interests. Sovereigns also have leverage as borrowers of which households or firms could only dream. And yet, the analogy of sovereigns “running up their credit cards” and “risking bankruptcy” is a perennial one in politics. There is much to criticize about this analogy.³ Perhaps its staying power is due to the kernel of truth therein: when debt gets too expensive, things cannot go on as before.

Support for austerity in the current moment in the United States is, in many ways, surprising; the academic literature generally presumes that financial crisis is a necessary

² 26 February 2025 cabinet meeting. On 21 February Milei gifted Musk a chainsaw onstage at the Conservative Political Action Conference.

³ Clarke (2025).

precursor.⁴ That there is hypocrisy, overclaiming, and partisan targeting in DOGE's actions, and that President Trump's domestic taxing and spending plans are incommensurate with debt reduction, are consistent with what the literature might expect – that austerity in good times is “cheap talk.”

And yet, in its first months the Trump II administration has made material cuts to US spending in one direction: international commitments to the institutions of the Liberal International Order (LIO). Simultaneously, the Trump administration has made cuts to policy complements of the LIO, most prominently radical tariff policy that ignores US obligations under its trade agreements and the WTO. While the situation is in flux at the time of writing, various administration officials have signaled that every country in the world (friend and foe alike) will face at best a 10% blanket tariff with the United States – orders of magnitude larger than tariffs that previously averaged under 3%.⁵

We connect the dots between debt and cuts to international obligations. If there is a real and growing sense that the US debt burden is unsustainable, then there is political room to do more than cosmetic cuts to US spending. Compared to the domestic alternatives, the institutions and policy offshoots of the LIO are more attractive targets. Clearly, choices are being filtered through a right-wing populist ideology dominant in the current Republican party, and changes are precipitated by an unconventional presidential race rather than acute financial crisis. But it is not in itself surprising that if austerity is the policy, then first-derivative cuts to international obligations come first.

⁴ On preferences over austerity given crisis, see e.g. Pinto et al (2025), Tobin et al (2022), Bansak et al (2021).

⁵ In 2016, before Trump took office, the simple mean was 2.8%; in 2024 it was 2.5% (World Bank WDI).

We think the best analogy for the current moment is Nixon on 15 August 1971, when the US “slammed the gold window shut” to end the Bretton Woods system of global exchange rate coordination. At the same time, Nixon implemented a radical set of policies that included cutting US foreign aid by 10% and temporarily surging US tariffs to 10%. This overnight regime change upended international finance, though a shift was widely anticipated due to the mounting strain in US domestic politics.⁶ Yet, international economic integration adapted rather than collapsed.

There are differences with the current moment. A debt crisis might be looming but is not imminent, and President Trump’s rhetoric has taken an axe to economic cooperation as an important goal more than Nixon’s ever did. And yet, deepening integration in the years and decades to follow suggests that continuity in US financial leadership, its debt burden be damned, is not necessary to sustain a cooperative international order. It would be a mistake to underestimate the rest of the world’s ability to adjust and sustain cooperation despite a fickle United States.

In the remainder of this piece, we explore these ideas in depth: evidence questioning the sustainability of US debt practices; reasons why international commitments are prime targets for real cuts; and the demonstrated capacity of the rest of the world to cooperate even when the US does not, with Nixon’s 1971 decision as historical precedent.

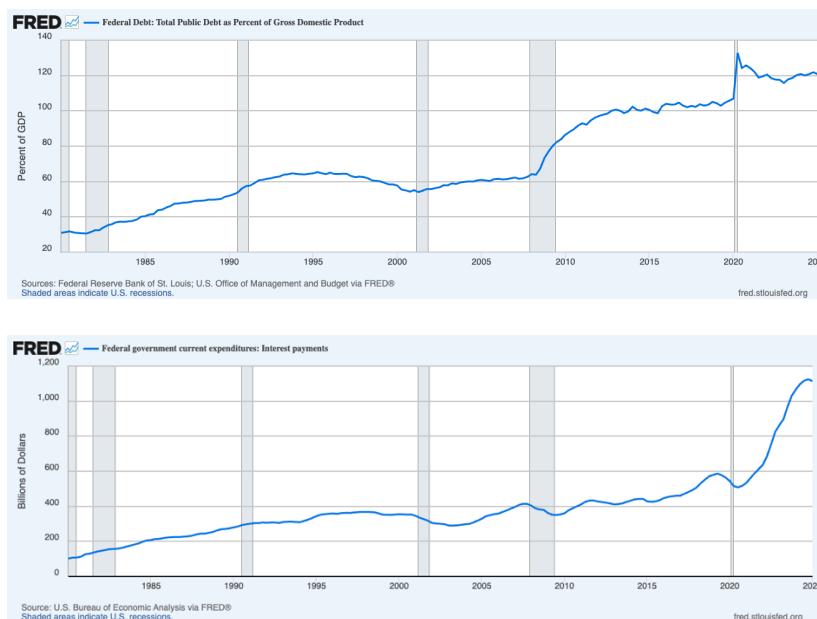
The rising threat of US debt

All three credit ratings agencies have now downgraded the United States: S&P in 2011; Fitch in 2023; and Moody’s in May 2025. From April to May 2025, the Trump II administration’s extreme “Liberation Day” tariffs and subsequent reversal following bond market backlash set

⁶ For the seminal study of Nixon’s decision, see Gowa (1983).

the stage for Moody's downgrade.⁷ Nonetheless, in its announcement Moody's increases "over more than a decade" in debt and interest payments as a portion of the government budget. Figure 1 illustrates the growing US debt burden and helps explain why concern over it is consolidating. The top panel shows the debt as a percentage of GDP; it has been over 100% since the mid-2010s. The bottom panel highlights the absolute growth in federal interest payments; the second derivative has skyrocketed in the last five years.

Figure 1. US federal debt and debt servicing indicators (annual, 1980-2025)



The political salience of the debt burden is surely tied to US interest rates, plotted in Figure 2. A downward trend prevailed for decades, but rates have now returned to levels last seen around the 1990s. While the future is uncertain, the US may be exiting a time-delimited era of interest rates so low as to make debt an issue of the second derivative and not the first.

⁷ On Trump and financial markets in his first term, see Benton and Philips (2020).

Though the analogy of the government as a household is flawed, persistently higher interest rates passing down to you and me surely feed into perceptions like Elon Musk's that radical austerity is "not an optional thing. It's essential."⁸

Figure 2. US interest rate, 1980 - 2025



It is also true that one could interpret Figure 2 as evidence that US interest rates remain at historic lows. Still, we think the change in trend activates an important principle in conservative politics: the need for precaution in taking on debt, especially as the burden grows. The precautionary principle, most famously associated with environmental policy, is a useful lens through which to understand this perspective. As articulated in the 1992 Rio Declaration on Environment and Development, "where there are threats of serious or irreversible damage, lack of full scientific certainty shall not be used as a reason for postponing cost-effective measures to prevent environmental degradation."⁹ This logic can be recast to any of a number of other policy areas, such as debt. The conceit is that debt risks serious or irreversible damage to the US economy. Though we lack full scientific certainty over the ideal debt level or the

⁸ 26 February 2025 cabinet meeting. On economic insecurity and populism, see Sheiring et al (2024) and Walter (2021).

⁹ Principle 15. On defining the precautionary principle, see Gardiner (2006).

consequences of current trends, the precautionary approach holds that uncertainty is no excuse for postponing painful policy measures.

Attitudes consistent with a precautionary approach to debt have been persistent, as evidenced by heated debates and split votes when Congress raises the debt ceiling.¹⁰ Moreover, meaningful portions of the US public worry about the national debt and even view it as personally relevant. For example, in a February 2025 poll, 22% responded that Trump/DOGE cuts to federal programs would directly help their family. Of those, one in five cited reduced government debt as the reason.¹¹ If we accept that conservative politics favors a higher level of precaution when it comes to incurring debt, even when borrowing is inexpensive, we can better understand why pro-austerity forces come out swinging under united Republican government and adverse trends. There is good-faith disagreement at play, and conservatives have a competitive advantage in activating it. The left does not like to talk about budget constraints.¹²

Institutions of the Liberal International Order are a ready target for austerity

That contemporary US conservative politics are taking the debt burden seriously is not at all to overlook hypocrisy evident in the Trump II administration's policies and proposals regarding debt accumulation. At the time of writing, the alliance between President Trump and Elon Musk has fractured precisely because Trump's FY2026 budget proposal is projected to explode US deficits and debt.¹³ Yet, with a chainsaw as a metaphor and anti-government

¹⁰ For example, in a 2015 poll 12% of respondents unconditionally supported raising the debt ceiling, with 67% expressing mixed views and 18% strongly opposing; in 2023 the results of a similar poll were 19%, 63%, and 16%. AP Poll: October 2015. [Roper #31113802]. AP-NORC Poll: May 2023. [Roper #31120285].

¹¹ CNN Poll: February 2025. [Roper #31122423].

¹² Right-wing parties are more likely to agree to debt terms that constrain future spending, even when alternatives are available (Ballard-Rosa, Mosley, and Wellhausen 2021).

¹³ After leaving DOGE, Musk called the bill a "disgusting abomination" and said it would "burden American citizens with crushingly unsustainable debt." Posts on X, June 2025.

populism finding resonance in the US electorate, the stage has been set for some genuine, non-cosmetic cuts.

In its first months, the targets of material cuts have been the institutions and complementary policies of the LIO. These actions appear to anticipate the outcome of the February 2025 Executive Order directing the Secretary of State and UN Ambassador to review all US memberships and financial contributions to IOs and treaties, with the goal of recommending “whether the United States should withdraw.”¹⁴ Among other measures, the United States has remained in arrears to the World Trade Organization, declined to fund the UN general budget, and ceased payments to various other IOs. The most visible complement to these cuts has been a sweeping increase in US tariff levels, which President Trump has promoted as a revenue-raising measure. The administration is also floating reclassifying as loans what were grants to international causes, with US demands of repayment from Ukraine for services rendered as an eye-popping example.¹⁵ Most drastically, US programs aimed at international audiences have been defunded, foremost among them USAID. According to the Trump II administration’s FY2026 discretionary budget request, USD 58.7 billion was enacted for State and International Programs in 2025, whereas the new request is only USD 9.6 billion.¹⁶

We set aside the question of whether such drastic actions are warranted, even under a precautionary approach to debt. Rather, if we accept that there is a political zeitgeist favoring

¹⁴ <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/02/withdrawing-the-united-states-from-and-ending-funding-to-certain-united-nations-organizations-and-reviewing-united-states-support-to-all-international-organizations/> The 180 day deadline is 3 August 2025.

¹⁵ The US-Ukraine minerals deal signed in May 2025 rolled back direct demands for repayment present in the first draft, but includes stipulations that can be understood as commitments to repayment in kind.

¹⁶ Table 2, OMB communication with Senate Committee on Appropriations, 2 May 2025. <https://www.whitehouse.gov/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/Fiscal-Year-2026-Discretionary-Budget-Request.pdf> Last accessed 12 June 2025.

first-order cuts to federal spending, then spending on the institutions of the LIO is a ready target.¹⁷ We see several arguments as to why.

First, the LIO's defenders point out that international spending is small, comprising only 0.7% to 1.4% of the budget between 2001 and 2023.¹⁸ At the same time, survey researchers consistently find that Americans vastly overestimate international aid's share of the budget. Polling also shows that many Americans today believe too much money is spent on aid; in March 2025, 52% of respondents expressed support for the drastic DOGE cuts to aid.¹⁹ This creates a near-perfect storm for political credit-claiming: an austerity-oriented administration can cut relatively small sums and get credit for enormous savings.²⁰

Second, what are the alternatives? Cuts to domestic services are not easy wins for a chainsaw approach. As a case in point, USAID defenders are advancing the argument that USAID programs constitute domestic spending on the US economy. For example, Congressional Democrats argue that foreign aid is an "effective investment in...economic growth" that can be used to "create new markets," while Republicans and Democrats have co-sponsored bills to restore the Food for Peace program, which purchases commodities from US farmers. Indeed, the nonpartisan Congressional Research Service explains that a key goal of USAID is to "assist US commercial interests."²¹ Scholar-activists have lamented the fact that foreign aid often boomerangs – spending flows back into the donor state's economy rather than to providers in

¹⁷ For cross-national evidence that governing parties find it difficult to commit to international economic integration and fulfill their campaign promises, see Schneider and Thomson (2024).

¹⁸ Desilver, Drew. 6 February 2025. "What the data says about US foreign aid." Pew Research Center.

¹⁹ Reuters/Ipsos Poll: 31 March – 2 April 2025. [Roper #31122559]

²⁰ On political credit claiming, see Jensen and Malesky (2018).

²¹ Sources: Amicus curiae brief by 202 Democratic members of Congress re: American Foreign Service Association v. President Trump (case 1:25-cv-00352-CJN); H.R. 1207 and S. 525; McCabe, Emily. 14 March 2025. "US Agency for International Development: An Overview." Congressional Research Service. Findley (2018) contextualizes aid as part of a suite of potentially substitutable foreign policy tools.

recipient states.²² Regardless, this design choice might be the most effective strategy to minimize foreign aid's attractiveness as a target for austerity.

Third, arguments over what these cuts will do to US goals in the international sphere are pockmarked with uncertainty. Commentators have raised the concept of “soft power” – a slippery and difficult to quantify concept.²³ Contemporary political discourse makes clear that there is no de facto agreement on what US “soft power” goals are. It cannot be assumed that US elites accept financial premiums in pursuit of environmental, social, and governance (ESG) goals; diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) goals; or liberal conceptions of human rights. Democracy promotion is not uncontroversial, especially given its interrelationship with the US use of coercion and force.²⁴ That promoting US economic activity abroad is inherently beneficial to the US writ large is also openly questioned.²⁵ Perhaps the era of cheap money – when disagreement could be expressed through shifts in priorities rather than absolute cuts – led academic literatures astray, presuming agreement on and continuity of US “soft power” goals that was never truly there.

Even assuming agreement on what US “soft power” goals constitute, the return on investment for each dollar of spending toward those goals is unclear. Put differently, it is not obvious how much can be cut before “soft power” is lost. Imagine if today's conservative movement fully understood the literature on the durability of even “zombie” international organizations. Inter alia, Eilstrup-Sangiovanni and Verdier (2024) document outgoing IOs that

²² OECD states (including the US) have made a variety of non-binding commitments to untie aid and prioritize in-country procurement, e.g. in the 2008 Accra Agenda for Action.

²³ For a qualitative account of US economic policy and declining soft power during the Trump I era, see Gallarotti (2023).

²⁴ On the “taming of democracy assistance,” see Bush (2015).

²⁵ On the intellectual origins of “autarkic thought” of the kind espoused by the Trump administration(s), see Helleiner (2021). For a Kantian perspective on contemporary economic institutions, see Isiksel (2020).

are succeeded by others. Of a sample of 70 international economic organizations (1948-2013), Gray (2018) documents that only 10% ever actually died. Morse and Keohane (2014) explain how contestation in existing IOs leads to the creation of new competitor IOs. If institutions persist and respawn, why must the US need take on costly obligations to champion them? The academic literature has not disproven the supposition that international institutions, or meaningful US influence within them, can survive cuts to US outlays.

This political moment is dramatic, because the idea of cutting not just the second derivative but breaking contracts is shocking to those accustomed to politics that shifts deck chairs under the auspices of stable institutions. Yet reasonable people do disagree over issues of “the means versus the ends,” and the increasing US debt burden provides kernels of truth underlying “the ends.” In a world in which money is expensive – or at least in the shadow of expensive money, taken up by political opportunists – it is understandable that the international becomes a first target.

International order is not predicated on US spending: Historical evidence

We think those lamenting the end of a cooperative international order are massively underestimating the ability of other states to sustain cooperation absent outsized US debt accumulation. Perhaps the best evidence that the rest of the world can adjust comes from the closest historical example of the US stepping back from its international financial commitments: when President Richard Nixon abruptly took the US off the gold standard and broke the post-WWII Bretton Woods cooperative exchange rate system. In a televised address on Sunday, 15 August 1971 (which preempted that week’s episode of *Gunsmoke*), Nixon announced that “the time has come for [other major industrial nations] to bear their fair share of the burden of

defending freedom around the world... There is no longer any need for the United States to compete with one hand tied behind her back.”²⁶ The *New York Times* called this “shock therapy” that “buried the ghost of Adam Smith” and threw foreign governments “into a tailspin.”²⁷

The Nixon administration did destroy an anchor of the status quo ante of economic cooperation, and global exchange rate cooperation has not revived. Among scholars, a robust discussion framed this as an inflection point heralding the US’s “lost hegemony” – an argument that Susan Strange (1987) presciently called a “persistent myth.”²⁸ Clearly, multinational business found a way forward; today’s quantitative studies of economic integration begin, rather than end, with data from the 1970s.²⁹ Continuity in both US influence and deepening integration is such that the regime change on 15 August 1971 is largely lost to history (except in IPE curricula).

What might be wrong with this historical comparison? First, neither Nixon nor anyone in his administration questioned economic integration itself.³⁰ Like Trump today, Nixon did impose a 10% global tariff – but that tariff had myriad exemptions, was deployed as a negotiating tactic to persuade allies to revalue their exchange rates, and was always labeled as temporary.³¹ Given Trump’s isolationist rhetoric and actions, it cannot be assumed that he is

²⁶ Transcript available via Office of the Federal Register (Ed.). Richard Nixon, containing the public messages, speeches and statements of the president - 1971. Washington: US Government Printing Office, 1972. 1362 p. (Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States). p. 886-890.

²⁷ Raskin, A. H. 22 August 1971. “The Nation.” *New York Times*: E1.

²⁸ Winecoff (2020) picks up where Strange left off, demonstrating that the US has maintained persistent structural power as a node in international economic and other networks despite ending Bretton Woods.

²⁹ Commenting on inflation and devaluation, Nixon said, “Hell, [it] doesn’t worry the bankers—they make it both ways.” “Report on the Meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Economic Policy,” 13 February 1969, p. 4. Quoted in Gowa (1983: 166).

³⁰ Gowa 1983; Eichengreen 2008.

³¹ As Irwin (2012) explains, the tariff covered 52% of US merchandise imports, because it was not applied to preexisting duty-free imports, or imports subject to quantitative restrictions (which included oil, several agricultural products, and cotton textiles). It was lifted four months later, after exchange rate negotiations with Japan and West Germany resulted in the Smithsonian Agreement.

guided by the same underlying preferences as Nixon. Second, the United States was on the precipice of severe crisis by the summer of 1971, although it struggled with its commitment to gold nearly from the beginning of Bretton Woods.³² Today, ratings agencies and other observers agree that the US is already struggling with its debt burden, but as argued above it is precaution rather than imminent crisis that underpins current austerity.

Regardless, this historical episode is instructive. US domestic politics precipitated retrenchment in its international financial commitments. The current administration may be enjoying the process more than Nixon did – Trump’s social media posts suggest as much – but that does not mean that international economic cooperation will be uprooted. Economic integration, and US influence therein, has already once survived and even thrived beyond a massive reduction in US international outlays.

Evidence of sustained international cooperation

The years and decades after 1971 demonstrate that, although its form was irrevocably changed, states continued economic integration and cooperation after the US ended Bretton Woods. There is already substantial evidence of similar outcomes today. Just some examples at the time of writing: Yes, the US has all but abandoned the multilateral trading regime.³³ Still, 52 WTO member states have devised a new dispute settlement body that Pelc (2024) calls “a prototype for institutional innovation in the face of hegemonic spoilers.” Trump has balked at the OECD agreement on a global minimum tax, but 40 states have already unilaterally

³² Previous administrations tried to limit capital outflows by, for example, limiting the number of dependents accompanying US military personnel stationed overseas (Eisenhower, 1960); taxing foreign securities issued in the US (Kennedy, 1964); and discouraging headquarters-to subsidiary transfers by US multinational corporations (Johnson, 1965). See Gowa (1983): pp 48, 55, 57.

³³ For an accounting, see in particular Goldstein and Gulotty (2021).

implemented it.³⁴ Trump did not send delegations to meetings around the newly negotiated Global Oceans Treaty (BBNJ), which the US signed in 2023; still, 116 parties have signed and 32 have ratified it.³⁵ While the US has for years been uninterested in trade agreements, 89 have been signed globally since 2016.³⁶ This is not to mention the activities of regional groups such as the African Union or cooperation among Global South states in the expanding BRICS. Even informal groups remain relevant, evinced by the G7's success in coordinating and growing international aid.³⁷

On the side of international business, Johns, Pelc, and Wellhausen (2019) reflected on the Trump I administration's disinterest in global economic governance and saw reason to expect multinational corporations to "fill this vacuum" (p 732). Looking forward, we expect that business interests will keep the sinews of international integration from breaking; US and Chinese walk-backs within weeks of their 145% and 125% tariffs speak to the unsustainability of what was effectively autarky between the world's biggest economies.

The US stepping back from international commitments is deeply disruptive. Nonetheless, if we focus on budget constraints, and take seriously that budget constraints are increasingly binding, then US spending on the LIO spending is a clear target. Perhaps the reality of deep cuts to US international spending have caught the rest of the world off-guard, as it has many in the United States (including us). But the example of Nixon 1971, as well as cooperation

³⁴ Pillar II of the Global Anti-Base Erosion (GloBE) Model Rules. On his first day in office, Trump issued a memo that "recaptures our Nation's sovereignty and economic competitiveness by clarifying that the Global Tax Deal has no force or effect in the United States." 20 January 2025. <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/01/the-organization-for-economic-co-operation-and-development-oecd-global-tax-deal-global-tax-deal/>

³⁵ Carver, Edward. 29 April 2025. "Under Trump, US retreats from global fisheries and oceans leadership." Mongabay. Sixty ratifications are required for the BBNJ to enter into force.

³⁶ Data from Dür et al (2014).

³⁷ Cormier, Heinzl, and Reinsberg (2024).

despite Trump today, suggests that a changed but still familiar international order can endure even when the United States retrenches.

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